

with India playing all seven preparatory games behind closed doors. The results, nevertheless, have been promising — of the seven games, it lost just twice, scoring 10 goals and conceding four.

Despite ticking several right boxes, India is not a favourite to lift the title. But there is more at stake here. At least six and up to eight countries will qualify for the 2027 Women's World Cup in Brazil — six via direct qualification and two through intercontinental playoffs.

"Our target is simple — to qualify for the World Cup, and this is the closest we have come to it. So, we have given the best possible facilities to the women's team. They completed their preparation overseas, in Turkey," Kalyan Chaubey, the All India Football Federation's president, said.

"We have made sure that a World Cup-tested coach manages the side. So, our agenda has been on the lines of what Swami Vivekananda said: 'Arise, awake and stop not till the goal is reached'."

In the Asian Cup, India will have to finish in the top two in its group or as one of the two best third-placed teams to enter the knockouts. It will then have

The larger picture

India is not alone in rewriting its script. For the first time in 27 years, two countries from South Asia — India and Bangladesh — have qualified for the tournament, with Bangladesh making its debut.

Bangladesh faced huge controversy when Peter Butler took over as head coach, with about a dozen national team players boycotting the side. Butler then rebuilt the team from the ground up, scripting a golden chapter in the country's footballing history.

Iran, on the other hand, secured consecutive Asian Cup qualifications, this time under legendary coach Marzieh Jafari. In 2003, a devastating earthquake claimed the lives of all players on the first futsal team she founded.

But instead of succumbing to the pain, she chose reconstruction. Having won eight women's top-flight titles, she will now look to inspire the national team in Australia.

Meanwhile, Australia enters the tournament as one of the clear favourites, alongside

Japan, defending champion China and North Korea.

The host has European stars in Sam Kerr, Ellie Carpenter, Caitlin Foord and Kyra Cooney-Cross, and after a remarkable fourth-place finish at the 2023 World Cup, it will look to continue its purple patch on home soil.

But beneath the spectacle lies an uncomfortable disparity: the prize money. The Women's European Championship has a prize pool of USD 47.2 million, the 2024 Women's African Cup of Nations features a prize pot of USD 3.475 million, while the 2025 Copa America Femenina awards USD 2 million.

In contrast, the Women's Asian Cup's prize pot has remained USD 1.8 million, unchanged from the previous edition, making it the lowest-paying continental tournament in the world.

For India, though, it has never been about the money this time.

Its redemption arc in the Asian Cup may be complete, but it now has a chance to take a step further — by qualifying for the World Cup and altering the trajectory of women's football in India forever.



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three pathways to secure a historic World Cup qualification: seal a semifinal spot, win the play-ins, or triumph in the intercontinental playoffs.

"Our target has always been to reach Brazil and feel the World Cup experience. Now, we are just one step away," Sangita told AIFF.com. "We have to prove ourselves in Australia, represent the national team, and carry our flag forward."

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